



# Human Device Interaction (HDI)

## Interface better? Better interfaces?

**H**ow long are we going to be tied to the keyboard and mouse? How long will we have to type SMSes and make phone calls using our already sore thumbs?

Over the years, we have heard of and seen a lot of technologies that promise to radically change the way we interact with technology, gadgets, and gizmos. The keyboard-and-mouse was revolutionary, then came the stylus and tablet PCs, speech recognition promised but still needs some work, eye control and brain control is being researched with prototypes already out... the future seems promising, or is it just teasing us?

In recent times, two products have caught the world's fancy: the iPhone and the Wii. The iPhone is remarkable for a lot of reasons, including the fact that it runs OS X on a phone, but it captures the limelight mainly because of its interface. It's not new technology, not by a long shot... all Apple's done is use its patented

multi-touch technology on a screen, something that MacBook users have already become used to when using the touch-pads on their laptops. A touch-pad that recognises the touch of two or more fingers isn't wild enough to have technology enthusiasts raving, but the fact that it's on a phone is good because it changes things radically. No more pressing buttons, just tap screens. Pinch to zoom in, reverse the action to zoom out. The iPod is already famous for its much-acclaimed interface, as is Mac OS X.

The Nintendo Wii, on the other hand, changed things drastically. The controllers are simple but brilliant, and get us more involved with the games we play, and Wii are loving it! Shameless puns aside, you can read more about it in the Gaming section of our Sixth Sense special. For our purpose, however, it's the way you interact with the Wii that catches our fancy. The Wiimote and the Nunchuk are cool, realistic controls, and hold a lot of promise for near-future products—even for PC gaming. We expect a lot of products that focus on actual movement to crop up in the next few years.

Operating systems today seem to have gone 3D in order to look better and help you put things in perspective when using the PC. Both hardware and software have a role to play when it comes to HDI. Vista and OS X apart, you should check out Project Looking Glass (PLG—[www.sun.com/software/looking\\_glass/](http://www.sun.com/software/looking_glass/)), open source software that promises to make the entire PC environment a 3D world, with the ability to see what's on the back of the regular windows you work with.

Consider a bookmark: it's just an icon in your favourites menu, but what if you could load the bookmarked site, flip the window around and write notes on the back of the browser window? With PLG, you can!

We're not here to state what is obvious to everyone though, and it's time to light the incense, sit in a circle, join hands, and gaze into the crystal ball...

Speech recognition seems to be the most promising form of input yet. Why type when you can dictate? The problem is that speech recognition systems generally fail to be of any use in noisy environments. The immediate future will definitely see more of them, and hopefully, noise reduction will bring up the accuracy of the software.

Coming back to touch screens, we've mentioned the iPhone's multi-touch screen about a gazillion times, but even that seems lame when we talk about Jeff Han, a consultant for New York



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